



Refusal Skills and Coping Mechanisms

Practicing healthy responses to substance use

 In this activity, you will learn how to make healthy decisions by practicing refusal skills and identifying positive ways to cope with pressure.

Explore healthy decision-making

Making healthy choices helps you stay in control of your future. Sometimes, you may face situations where you feel pressured to try things that are not good for your body or mind. Learning how to say no clearly and how to handle stress in positive ways makes you stronger and more confident.

Term	Definition
Refusal Skills	A refusal skill is a way to say no firmly and clearly when you feel pressured. It helps you stay true to your values.
Coping Mechanism	A coping mechanism is a way to manage stress or difficult feelings. These are healthy actions like talking to a friend or playing sports.

Read the guide carefully

Read the following text about staying safe. As you read, ask yourself: How can I prepare my responses before I am in a difficult situation?

*It is normal to feel nervous when you are asked to do something you know is not safe. Substance use, which means taking things like tobacco, alcohol, or other drugs, can harm your brain and body as you grow.

To protect yourself, you can use "I" statements to be clear. For example, say "I do not want to do that because I want to stay healthy." If the pressure continues, the best choice is to walk away and find a safe environment.

Healthy coping means finding ways to feel good without using substances. You can listen to music, practice deep breathing, or talk to a trusted adult. By having a plan, you can act quickly and keep your well-being a priority.*



Build your connections

Use the ideas from the text to complete the table below.

Key Concept	Your Understanding	Why is this important?
Refusal Skills	<i>Saying no clearly.</i>	<i>It helps protect your health.</i>
Coping Mechanism	Write your answer here	Write your answer here
Add a row or column as needed		



Try it out now

Use what you learned to solve these situations.

Scenario Question	Response
What would you say if someone offered you something unsafe at a party?	Write your answer here
What is one healthy activity you can do when you feel stressed?	



Show what you learned

Create a digital visual project that shows your understanding of refusal skills. Use Magic Media or Elements to help visualise or record your idea.

- Brainstorm three clear refusal phrases.
- Choose a background that represents a healthy environment.
- Add icons for your favorite healthy coping mechanisms.
- Combine your text and images into a final layout.

[Double click to design here]



Reflect on your work

Think about how you have grown during this activity.

List one refusal skill you feel confident using in your daily life.

[Write your answer here.]

How does having a plan help you feel more in control when you face peer pressure?

What is one thing you would like to learn more about to stay healthy?